Five Spooky Sky Targets to Spot This Halloween Season

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Halloween is a perfect excuse to look up, because the autumn sky is full of myths and bright surprises. You do not need a telescope for these five targets, just a dark sky and patience. Start with the **Pleiades**, a tight cluster that looks like six or seven bright stars to the naked eye. Binoculars reveal dozens more from a cluster of about 1,000 stars. Ancient Celtic druids celebrated **Samhain**, a forerunner of Halloween, when the **Pleiades** reached its highest point at midnight in autumn, a time when people once believed the veil between the living and the dead was thinnest. From the United States, find the three stars of Orion's Belt before midnight, follow an imaginary line upward to the bright orange star Aldebaran, then look a little higher. Next, meet Algol, nicknamed the Demon Star, an eye of the Gorgon Medusa in the **constellation** Perseus. Algol is really two stars orbiting each other. Every 2.867 days, one star passes in front of the other, making Algol look about 3.3 times dimmer during a 10-hour **eclipse**. It will not be **eclipsed** on Halloween night in 2026, but dimming may be visible around October 29 and November 1. Then look southeast after sunset for Cetus, the sea monster or whale, whose circlet of stars shines to the right of the **Pleiades**. Around the full moon on October 26, look for bright, spiderweb-like streaks around the Moon craters Tycho, Copernicus, and Kepler. They are bright material thrown out by the impacts that made those young craters, best seen at full moon. Finally, watch for the Taurid **meteors**, bright and slow-moving, seeming to streak away from a patch of sky near the **Pleiades** in Taurus. They take patience and luck, but one long fireball can make the night feel magical.

Word Treasure

Pleiades -- A tight group of young stars that look close together in the sky.
Samhain -- An old Celtic festival that was an early form of Halloween.
constellation -- A group of stars that people picture as a shape, like a hero or an animal.
eclipse -- When one star passes in front of another and blocks some of its light.
meteors -- Streaks of light made when bits of space dust burn up in the sky.

Background you need

A constellation is a group of stars that people long ago joined into a picture, such as a hero or a sea monster, and many of these pictures come from old myths.

A star cluster is a group of stars born close together and still travelling together through space.

Meteors are streaks of light made when small bits of space dust burn up in Earth's air, and they can look brightest on dark, clear nights.

The bright streaks around some Moon craters are material thrown out when space rocks crashed into the Moon long ago.

Break it down

LEAD: Five naked-eye sky targets are worth watching around Halloween.
KEY EVENT: A guide to the Pleiades, Algol, Cetus, Moon craters, and Taurid meteors.
+- WHO: Stargazers in the United States, using no telescope.
+- WHAT: A star cluster, an eclipsing star, a constellation, crater streaks, and meteors.
+- WHEN: Around Halloween, including the October 26 full moon.
EVIDENCE: Algol dims every 2.867 days, and the Pleiades cluster holds about 1,000 stars.
CLOSING NOTE: The Taurid meteors take patience and luck, but one long fireball can make the night feel magical.

Why it matters

Knowing what to look for turns an ordinary autumn night into a chance to see real stars, myths, and meteors with your own eyes.

Test what you remember

1. How many bright stars does the Pleiades look like to the naked eye?

- (A) About 1,000
- (B) Three
- (C) Six or seven
- (D) Two

2. How can you find the Pleiades from the United States?

- (A) Find Orion's Belt, follow a line up to Aldebaran, then look higher
- (B) Find Cetus first, then look left
- (C) Follow the Moon's craters
- (D) Look directly overhead at sunset

3. What is Algol, really?

- (A) A bright meteor
- (B) A single Demon Star
- (C) Two stars orbiting each other
- (D) A planet in Perseus

4. How often does Algol dim?

- (A) Only on Halloween night
- (B) Every full moon
- (C) Every 2.867 days, when one star passes in front of the other
- (D) Once a year in October

5. Will Algol be eclipsed on Halloween night in 2026?

- (A) Yes, for 10 hours
- (B) Yes, all night
- (C) No, and it will not dim at all that season
- (D) No, but dimming may be visible around October 29 and November 1

6. What are the bright streaks around the Moon craters Tycho, Copernicus, and Kepler?

- (A) Bright material thrown out by the impacts that made those craters
- (B) Shadows of mountains
- (C) Clouds on the Moon
- (D) Lights from Moon bases

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: C 4: C 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):